RFI#26006369

Statewide Student Transportation Services

for the State of Rhode Island

Response to Request for Information

Submitted by Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions

Submitted to:

State of Rhode Island
Department of Elementary and Secondary Education
Division of Statewide Transportation Services

March 19, 2026

SENTRY

Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions

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1 Letter of Transmittal

March 19, 2026

Rhode Island Department of Elementary and Secondary Education
Division of Purchases
Statewide Transportation Services
Providence, Rhode Island

RE: RFI#26006369 — Statewide Student Transportation Services

Dear Members of the Review Committee,

Fejost LLC, doing business as **Sentry Management Solutions** ("Sentry"), is pleased to submit this response to RIDE's Request for Information regarding Statewide Student Transportation Services. We appreciate the opportunity to contribute to the development of an RFP that will shape the future of student transportation in Rhode Island for the 2027–2028 school year and beyond.

Who We Are

Sentry Management Solutions is a New York–based transportation management and technology company founded in 2016. *2–3 sentences describing Sentry's core capabilities in routing optimization, dispatch technology, fleet management, video monitoring, and analytics. Reference current scale of operations (e.g., MTA paratransit volume).*

Our Interest in the STS

Technology & System Management:
Sentry offers RIDE an enterprise-grade platform for routing optimization, real-time dispatch, fleet analytics, and video violation detection monitoring—capabilities that align directly with the 2025 legislative mandates and the Workgroup's efficiency goals.

Vendor-Neutral Integration:
Our technology is designed to operate across multiple bus operators and zones, providing RIDE with centralized visibility regardless of which contractors are awarded individual zones.

Data-Driven Cost Reduction:
Brief statement on how Sentry's analytics capabilities address RIDE's deadhead reduction, ghost rider elimination, and van optimization goals.

Video Violation Detection Readiness:
Brief statement on Sentry's readiness to deploy live digital video violation detection systems ahead of the July 1, 2027 mandate for new buses.

Authorized Representative

The person authorized to represent Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions is:

SENTRY

Name: Max Zinner

Title: *Title*

Phone: *Phone*

Email: *Email*

Address: *Address*

Contact for Clarification

Name: Max Zinner

Title: *Title*

Phone: *Phone*

Email: *Email*

This response is submitted for informational purposes in accordance with the terms of RFI#26006369. We understand that no award will be made as a result of this solicitation and that all information marked as proprietary shall be treated as confidential.

Respectfully submitted,

Max Zinner
Title
Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions
(844) 573-6879 · info@sentryms.com

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3 Company Overview

3.1 Organization Summary

Organization Summary	
Legal Entity Name	Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions
Year Established	2016
Type of Ownership	Limited Liability Company (LLC)
Parent Company	None — Sentry is an independent, privately held company
Headquarters	*Address*
Total Full-Time Employees	*Number*
Primary Contact	Max Zinner, *Title*
Phone / Email	*Phone* / *Email*
Website	www.sentryms.com

3.2 Sentry's Role in Student Transportation

2–3 paragraphs describing Sentry's positioning as a technology and system management provider for student transportation. Emphasize that Sentry is NOT a bus operator but rather provides the technology platform and management services that bus operators and state agencies rely on for routing, dispatch, fleet management, video monitoring, and analytics.

Core Capabilities

Routing Optimization:
Describe routing engine, algorithm capabilities, multi-zone optimization

Real-Time Dispatch:
Describe dispatch platform, GPS tracking, ETAs

Video Violation Detection:
Describe camera systems, AI detection, violation processing pipeline

Analytics & Reporting:
Describe dashboards, KPI tracking, cost analysis tools

Fleet Management:
Describe preventive maintenance tracking, vehicle lifecycle management

Parent & Driver Communication:
Describe parent app, driver app, real-time notifications

3.3 Relevant Experience

2–3 paragraphs describing Sentry's most relevant engagements. Reference MTA paratransit scale (10,000+ daily trips), school district work, and any video monitoring deployments. Emphasize experience with multi-vendor, multi-zone environments analogous to RIDE's STS structure.

Key Engagement Title	
Client	*Client Name*
Contract Value	*$X*
Fleet / Scale	*Description*
Daily Volume	*Description*
Technology Deployed	*Description of systems provided*
Service Area	*Geography*

3.4 Understanding of Rhode Island's STS

Sentry has carefully studied the current structure of RIDE's Statewide Transportation System, established by the General Assembly in FY 2009 under RIGL § 16-21.1 and phased in over three years (14 LEAs in 2010, 26 in 2011, all LEAs by 2012). The system today operates across seven zones serving approximately 3,812 students through 334 routes coordinated by the current Statewide System Manager, **Transpar**, on behalf of 49 LEAs plus out-of-state placements. RIDE's own *Statewide Transportation System Overview* (October 2024) demonstrates that this system has grown by **34%** in ridership since 2015—from 2,850 to 3,812 students—even as total Rhode Island student enrollment has *declined* by 4% (141,959 to 136,154). The system's FY 2025 cost exceeds **$41 million**.

This demand growth is driven by three distinct student populations, each with unique routing and compliance requirements:

- **PCCT (Private, Charter, Career & Technical)** — 50.87% of riders. Regional boundaries under RIGL § 16-21.1-2 apply to this population. The Meeting Street example illustrates the consolidation advantage: statewide routing reduced buses serving that single school from 28 to 13—a 54% reduction.
- **Special Education** — 24.29% of riders (234 of 334 routes). Required by federal law (IDEA); regional boundaries do *not* apply. Routes must accommodate wheelchair accessibility, 1:1 aides, and IEP-mandated maximum ride times.
- **Homeless & Foster Care (McKinney-Vento)** — 24.84% of riders. Required by federal law; regional boundaries do *not* apply. Addresses change frequently, requiring dynamic route adjustment.

We are particularly attentive to the three bills passed into law in 2025 as a result of the Student Transportation Workgroup's recommendations:

- **Increased Van Size** — The expanded 10-passenger definition presents an opportunity to convert qualifying routes from higher-cost school buses to vans, reducing per-route costs while maintaining service quality. RIDE has already begun "rightsizing" by increasing vans and minibuses; 147 of 334 vehicles are already vans.
- **Temporary School Bus Driver Licenses** — Abbreviated CDL training for border-state residents can accelerate recruitment pipelines, addressing the driver shortage that competes with Uber, DoorDash, RIPTA, FedEx, and Amazon for the same labor pool. Notably, RI's unique "white card" requirement—a multi-day course at CCRI plus DMV driving tests—remains a barrier for out-of-state CDL holders even with the new temporary license provision.

- **Live Digital Video Violation Detection Systems** — The July 1, 2027 mandate for new buses (and July 1, 2032 for all buses) creates an immediate need for a technology partner capable of deploying, managing, and processing video violation data at scale.

4 Inquiries Regarding Potential Barriers to Entry

RFI Reference
Section C: Questions to Field — Inquiries Regarding Potential Barriers to Entry (Questions 1–4)

4.1 Question 1

"What, if anything, may prevent your company from bidding on this scope of work?"

Address Sentry's specific barriers honestly. Key points to cover:

- ***Fleet & Drivers:*** *Sentry does not own or operate a bus fleet and does not directly employ CDL drivers. Our participation depends on whether RIDE structures the RFP to include a separate technology/system management component, or whether we can partner with a bus operator.*
- ***RI Presence:*** *Sentry does not currently have an operational footprint in Rhode Island. If yard space, fuel access, or local infrastructure are preconditions for bidding, state-provided support (per Question 4) would be critical.*
- ***Procurement Structure:*** *If the RFP is structured exclusively for vertically integrated bus operators (i.e., one vendor provides buses, drivers, AND technology), Sentry would be unable to bid independently. A structure that separates technology/system management from vehicle operations would enable our participation.*

4.2 Question 2

"What contract structure(s) would make participation in RIDE's Statewide Transportation System (STS) more feasible for your organization? For example, would any of the following potential contract structures make it more likely that your organization would bid on this scope of work?"

Sentry strongly encourages RIDE to consider the following contract structures, which would increase competition, attract specialized providers, and ultimately deliver better outcomes for Rhode Island students:

- **Separate Technology / System Management Contract:**
  Advocate for a standalone technology procurement—a "Statewide System Manager" contract covering routing optimization, dispatch, fleet analytics, video monitoring, and parent communication. This allows RIDE to select best-in-class technology independently of bus operator selection, ensures vendor-neutral oversight across all zones, and avoids the conflict of interest when operators self-report performance data.
- **Multiple Vendor Awards per Zone:**
  Allowing multiple vendors per zone would enable technology providers like Sentry to partner with bus operators, bringing specialized routing and monitoring capabilities to zones where operators may lack in-house technology.
- **Allowing Subcontracting or Partnerships:**
  Cross-zone partnerships would enable smaller or specialized firms to combine resources. Sentry could serve as the technology backbone for one or more bus operators across multiple zones, creating a more competitive field.
- **Subdividing Larger Zones:**
  Smaller zones lower the fleet threshold for entry, encouraging regional and minority-owned operators to participate. Sentry's routing platform can optimize routes regardless of zone boundaries, ensuring efficiency is not lost through subdivision.

Recommendation to RIDE

RIDE already operates with a separate System Manager—Transpar currently provides routing, program billing, vendor performance monitoring, and customer service support across all 49 LEAs. The RFP is an opportunity to *strengthen* this model by procuring an upgraded technology platform with modern capabilities: AI-powered routing optimization, real-time GPS dispatch, live video violation detection, and automated cost analytics. A next-generation System Manager would replace the current 700-check-per-year manual billing process, eliminate annual paper re-enrollment that contributes to the 550 "ghost rider" problem, and give RIDE independent performance data rather than relying on operator self-reports.

4.3 Question 3

"What minimum route density or fleet size makes bidding on a zone more viable for your organization?"

As a technology provider, Sentry's viability is not tied to route density or fleet size in the traditional sense. Our platform scales from 29 routes (Zone D) to 122+ routes (Zone A1) with equal efficiency. Address this from both angles:

- ***As technology provider:*** *No minimum — the platform is zone-agnostic and scales linearly. In fact, deploying across ALL zones is most efficient, as it enables cross-zone optimization.*
- ***If partnering with a bus operator:*** *The partner operator's fleet and driver minimums would apply. Generally, 25–30 routes represents a viable minimum for a dedicated depot.*

4.4 Question 4

"What support (e.g., yard space, fuel access, maintenance facilities, etc.) could the State provide or assist with that would make it more likely for your organization to bid?"

Data Access:

Providing prospective bidders with anonymized route data, student origin/destination data (FERPA-compliant), current schedules, and historical performance metrics would allow technology providers to demonstrate value through optimized routing scenarios during the RFP process.

Technology Infrastructure:

State-provided or state-facilitated access to API integrations with existing RIDE systems (student information systems, IEP databases) would accelerate deployment and reduce implementation risk.

Yard Space & Facilities:

State-owned or state-leased yard space available to new entrant operators would reduce the capital barrier for bus operators partnering with technology providers like Sentry.

Fuel Access:

Centralized fueling contracts or bulk purchasing arrangements could reduce costs for smaller operators and level the playing field against incumbents with established fueling infrastructure.

Extended Transition Period:

A transition period longer than 8 months (November 2026 award to July 2027 service start) would give new entrants time to establish local operations, recruit drivers, and deploy technology.

5 Operational Efficiencies

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Operational Efficiencies (Questions 1–3)

5.1 Question 1: Deadhead Reduction Strategies

"In general, please describe your company's deadhead reduction strategies."

This is a critical question for RIDE given the extreme deadhead inefficiency in Zones C and D (2h12m to 3h38m of deadhead overhead per route). Sentry's response should demonstrate deep understanding of the problem and concrete technology-driven solutions.

The Deadhead Problem in Context: RIDE's own data reveals significant variation in deadhead time across zones. Zones C and D show average route times of 6h07m and 7h05m *including* deadhead, but only 3h55m and 3h27m of productive service time—meaning 36–51% of total route time is non-revenue deadhead mileage. With ridership up 34% since 2015 (2,850 to 3,812 students) and close to 100 more buses per day on the road, deadhead reduction is now a $41M system's largest efficiency lever.

Describe Sentry's approach to deadhead reduction. Key strategies to cover:

Algorithm-Based Route Optimization:
Describe how Sentry's routing engine minimizes deadhead by clustering pickups/drop-offs geographically, optimizing depot placement, and sequencing routes to minimize empty miles between runs.

Dynamic Depot Assignment:
Describe how routes can be assigned to the nearest available depot or staging area rather than a fixed home base, reducing the initial deadhead leg.

Multi-Run Chaining:
Describe how AM and PM routes can be chained with midday routes (PCCT, McKinney-Vento) to keep vehicles productive and reduce return-to-depot deadhead between runs.

Cross-Zone Optimization:
Describe how a centralized routing platform can identify opportunities to assign routes near zone boundaries to the closest depot regardless of zone, reducing deadhead that results from artificial geographic boundaries. Reference the Meeting Street consolidation example: centralized routing reduced buses serving that school from 28 to 13 (54% reduction)—this same logic applied system-wide across 500+ destination schools is where transformative savings occur.

Deadhead Reduction Potential

Quantify the potential savings. Example: "Based on RIDE's published route data, optimization of Zones C and D alone could reduce deadhead time by an estimated 25–35%, translating to approximately X fewer bus-hours per day and $X in annual fuel and labor savings."

5.2 Question 2: Preventive Maintenance Efficiency Metrics

"Please describe your company's preventive maintenance efficiency metrics and how those relate to how your organization best-manages its preventative maintenance program."

Describe Sentry's approach to preventive maintenance tracking and fleet management. Sentry provides the technology platform that enables operators to manage PM programs—not the wrench-turning itself.

PM Scheduling Engine:

Describe automated maintenance scheduling based on mileage, engine hours, calendar intervals, and manufacturer specifications. System generates work orders and tracks completion.

Fleet Health Dashboard:

Describe real-time visibility into fleet status—vehicles due for PM, overdue units, out-of-service rates, mean time between failures (MTBF), and parts inventory levels.

Pre- & Post-Trip Inspection Digitization:

Describe how drivers complete inspections on tablets/phones, defects are flagged immediately, and critical defects trigger automatic vehicle holds until resolved.

Key Metrics Tracked:

- **PM Compliance Rate:** *Target % and how it's measured*
- **Mean Distance Between Failures (MDBF):** *Target and benchmark*
- **Spare Ratio Utilization:** *Target % of spares deployed on any given day*
- **Road Call Rate:** *Target per 100,000 miles*

5.3 Question 3: Driver Scheduling Efficiency Tools and Metrics

"Please describe your company's driver scheduling efficiency tools and metrics."

Describe Sentry's driver scheduling capabilities. Emphasize how technology reduces overtime, improves driver retention, and ensures compliance with hours-of-service rules.

Automated Bid/Assignment System:

Describe how drivers are matched to routes based on qualifications (CDL endorsements, special education training, language skills), seniority (union compliance), and geographic proximity to reduce personal deadhead.

Hours Optimization:

Describe how the system balances driver hours across the workforce to minimize overtime while ensuring adequate rest periods and compliance with DOT regulations.

Real-Time Absence Management:

Describe automated call-out detection, standby driver notification, and route reassignment to minimize service disruptions from driver absences.

Key Metrics:

- **Driver Utilization Rate:** *Productive hours as % of paid hours*
- **Overtime as % of Total Hours:** *Target and benchmark*
- **Open Route Rate:** *Routes without assigned driver on any given day*
- **Driver Turnover Rate:** *Annual % and improvement strategies*

6 Cost Controls

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Cost Controls (Questions 1–4)

Note: Per the RFI instructions, no pricing information is included. This section describes methodologies only.

6.1 Question 1: Cost Per Bus Per Day

"How do you address and apply cost per bus per day? (no pricing info, but explain your methodology)"

Explain how Sentry's analytics platform calculates and tracks cost per bus per day as a management tool. This is methodology, not pricing. Key components to address:

Cost Components:

Describe the cost elements rolled into the per-bus-per-day metric: driver wages and benefits, fuel, maintenance (scheduled + unscheduled), insurance, depreciation/lease cost, overhead allocation, and administrative burden.

Vehicle Type Stratification:

Our methodology stratifies cost per bus per day by vehicle type, recognizing that the cost profile of a 10-passenger van differs significantly from a Type A wheelchair-accessible bus or a Type C/D full-size bus. *Describe how this stratification enables more accurate budgeting and identifies which routes could benefit from right-sizing vehicles.*

Trend Analysis:

Describe how the platform tracks this metric over time to identify cost creep, seasonal variation, and the impact of efficiency initiatives (e.g., deadhead reduction, van conversion).

6.2 Question 2: Cost Per Mile

"What is your company's cost per mile methodology?"

Describe Sentry's cost-per-mile methodology. Key points:

Total Cost Per Mile:

All-in cost divided by total revenue miles (excluding deadhead). This gives the true cost of productive service.

Fuel Cost Per Mile:

Tracked separately to isolate fuel price volatility from operational efficiency. GPS-verified mileage eliminates odometer discrepancies.

Maintenance Cost Per Mile:

Tracked by vehicle age, type, and maintenance category (PM vs. breakdown) to identify vehicles approaching end-of-economic-life.

Loaded vs. Deadhead Mile Distinction:

Critical distinction—cost per loaded mile (with students aboard) is the true efficiency metric. Our platform separates these automatically via GPS geofencing at school and student pickup locations.

Cost Transparency for RIDE

RIDE currently uses an "expenditure follows the child" billing methodology, where the total cost of a route is proportionally divided among LEAs based on the number of students each district has on that route. Today, this billing process generates approximately 700 checks per year from districts to RIDE—an outdated manual system that RIDE's own October 2024 overview identifies as a weakness. Sentry's platform automates this cost allocation in real-time, tying GPS-verified route data directly to per-student billing and eliminating manual reconciliation. As an independent technology provider, Sentry gives RIDE visibility into cost metrics across all operators and zones—eliminating the information asymmetry that exists when operators self-report their own cost data.

6.3 Question 3: Spare Ratio Philosophy

"What is your company's spare ratio philosophy?"

Describe Sentry's approach to spare vehicle management. This is an area where technology can significantly reduce costs.

% Target Spare Ratio:
Industry standard is 15–20% spare ratio. Describe Sentry's recommended target and how it varies by vehicle type (higher for older fleets, lower for newer fleets with warranty coverage).

Dynamic Spare Deployment:
Describe how the platform tracks which spares are deployed daily, identifies patterns (e.g., certain routes or vehicle types that consistently pull spares), and flags when spare utilization trends upward—a leading indicator of fleet health problems.

Right-Sizing the Spare Pool:
Describe how analytics can identify opportunities to reduce spare count without impacting service reliability—e.g., if PM compliance improves and MDBF increases, fewer spares are needed.

6.4 Question 4: Average Driver Hours Per Route

"How do you address and apply average driver hours per route?"

Describe how Sentry measures and optimizes average driver hours per route.

Components of Driver Hours:
Break down the metric: pre-trip inspection, deadhead to first pickup, loaded service time, deadhead return, post-trip inspection, and administrative time. The platform captures each component separately via GPS and driver app timestamps.

Optimization Levers:
Describe how each component can be reduced: deadhead reduction (routing optimization), pre/post-trip efficiency (digital inspections), and administrative time reduction (automated timekeeping).

Split-Shift vs. Straight-Time Analysis:
Describe how the platform models whether split-shift assignments (AM + PM with unpaid break) or straight-time assignments (driver stays on clock for midday routes) are more cost-effective for each zone.

Note on RIDE's Current Data: The RFI data shows average route times ranging from 4h28m (Zone A3) to 7h05m (Zone D) including deadhead. Sentry's platform would decompose these averages into their component parts, enabling RIDE to identify exactly where time (and money) is being lost on each route. Critically, this analysis must account for the system's changing demand profile: PCCT students—who constitute 50.87% of riders—are subject to regional boundaries, while Special Education (24.29%) and Homeless/Foster Care (24.84%) riders are federally mandated regardless of region. A driver hour optimization that works for a predictable PCCT route may not apply to a McKinney-Vento route where student addresses change frequently.

7 Routing

RFI Reference
Section C: Questions to Field — Routing (Questions 1–3)

7.1 Question 1: Collaboration with a Centralized Routing Authority

"How do you or would you collaborate with a centralized routing authority, such as the Statewide System Manager?"

RIDE already operates with a centralized System Manager—**Transpar**—which currently handles routing and program billing, vendor performance monitoring, customer service support, and coordination with 49 LEAs plus out-of-state placements. This structure validates the System Manager concept. Sentry's response addresses how we would serve as a next-generation System Manager or integrate with an existing authority.

Sentry as the Next-Generation System Manager:

Describe how Sentry's platform can serve as an upgraded centralized routing authority—receiving student enrollment data from RIDE's eRIDE system, generating optimized routes using AI-powered algorithms, distributing route assignments to zone operators, and automating the "expenditure follows the child" billing that currently generates 700 manual checks per year. This model preserves what works about the current Transpar arrangement while adding capabilities the system needs: real-time GPS dispatch, video violation processing, automated ghost rider detection, and cross-zone route optimization.

Integration with the Existing Authority:

If RIDE retains Transpar as System Manager, describe how Sentry's platform integrates via open APIs, GTFS-compatible data exchange, and real-time GPS feeds to augment Transpar's capabilities with technology tools not currently available—particularly routing optimization, video violation detection, and predictive analytics.

Vendor-Neutral Oversight:

Emphasize that a centralized routing authority should be independent of bus operators to avoid conflicts of interest. When operators control their own routing, they may optimize for their convenience (minimizing their costs) rather than for system-wide efficiency (minimizing RIDE's costs). The current model—where Transpar sits between RIDE and operators—is structurally sound; the opportunity is to equip that role with modern technology.

Recommendation: RIDE's existing System Manager model is a proven structure. The 2027 procurement is an opportunity to upgrade the technology powering that role. Sentry recommends that the RFP formalize the System Manager as a separate technology procurement, ensuring that the platform serving all 49 LEAs and 334 routes is selected on the basis of technological capability—not bundled as an afterthought into a bus operator's bid.

7.2 Question 2: Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

"What Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) do you believe the State should be using to measure routing efficiency across the STS?"

Sentry recommends the following KPIs for measuring routing efficiency across the STS:

KPI	Definition	Target / Benchmark
On-Time Performance	% of routes arriving within X minutes of scheduled time	*$\geq$ 95%*
Deadhead Ratio	Deadhead miles ÷ total miles	*$\leq$ 20% (currently 36–51% in Zones C/D)*
Students Per Route	Average students transported per route per day	*Varies by route type*
Ride Time Compliance	% of students with ride times $\leq$ maximum (IEP/policy)	*$\geq$ 98%*
Vehicle Utilization	Revenue hours ÷ total available hours	*$\geq$ 70%*
Route Change Turnaround	Time from route change request to service delivery	*$\leq$ 48 hours*
Cost Per Student Per Day	Total daily cost ÷ students transported	*Benchmark by zone*
Ghost Rider Rate	Enrolled students who never ride ÷ total enrolled	*$\leq$ 5% (currently ~16%)*
Spare Ratio	Spare vehicles ÷ routes operated	*15–20%*
Road Call Rate	Mechanical failures per 100,000 miles	*$\leq$ 5.0*

Data-Driven Accountability

These KPIs are only meaningful if measured independently from bus operators. Transpar currently monitors vendor performance, but the next-generation System Manager platform should collect, calculate, and report these metrics directly to RIDE from GPS, ridership, and operational data—not from operator self-reports. Sentry's platform generates KPI dashboards automatically from real-time vehicle and ridership data, giving RIDE the same independent oversight across all zones and operators.

7.3 Question 3: Turnaround Time for Route Changes

"What is your company or organization's reasonable timeframe to turn around service delivery for any route changes or additions within the proposed scope?"

Describe Sentry's capability for rapid route modification. Key points:

Same-Day Changes:

Minor modifications (stop additions, time adjustments, student additions to existing routes) can be processed and communicated to drivers within 2–4 hours.

24–48 Hour Changes:

New route creation, route splitting, or significant restructuring can be modeled, optimized, and deployed within 24–48 hours.

Seasonal / Systemic Changes:

Large-scale changes (zone restructuring, summer-to-school-year transitions, new school openings) require 2–4 weeks for modeling, driver bidding, and communication.

Contrast this with the current system where route changes may depend on operator willingness and capacity. A centralized routing platform ensures that RIDE—not the operator—controls the pace of change.

8 Company Practices Disclosure

"Please disclose your company practices in the following areas:"

RFI Reference
Section C: Questions to Field — Company Practices Disclosure (Items 1–3)

8.1 Item 1: Driver Recruitment Pipeline

Describe Sentry's approach to driver recruitment. As a technology provider, frame this as the tools and systems Sentry provides to operators for recruitment, while also describing any direct hiring experience from paratransit operations.

Recruitment Technology:

Describe digital recruitment tools—applicant tracking systems, targeted advertising platforms, referral bonus management, and integration with CDL training programs.

CDL Pipeline Development:

Describe partnerships with CDL training schools, "earn while you learn" programs, and how Sentry helps operators build a pipeline of CDL-ready candidates. Reference the new RI temporary license provision for border-state residents.

Retention as Recruitment:

Describe how driver retention tools (scheduling fairness, route preference systems, performance recognition, real-time communication) reduce the need for constant recruitment. Reference experience from MTA paratransit driver management.

Rhode Island Context: The September 2024 service crisis demonstrated the consequences of inadequate driver recruitment—Dattco deployed CT-based drivers who lacked the RI "white card" (a multi-day course at CCRI plus DMV driving tests unique to Rhode Island). Even with the new temporary license provision for border-state CDL holders, recruitment pipelines must account for this RI-specific credentialing timeline. Additionally, driver competition from Uber, DoorDash, RIPTA, FedEx, and Amazon has intensified the shortage. RIDE's October 2024 system overview identifies this as the system's most significant threat. Sentry supports RIDE's proposed **Bus Driver Apprenticeship program** concept and can provide the workforce management technology to administer it at scale.

8.2 Item 2: Training Hours Per Driver

Describe training program structure and hours. Distinguish between initial training and ongoing/refresher training.

Training Module	Initial Hours	Annual Refresher
CDL / School Bus Endorsement Preparation	*X hrs*	N/A
Defensive Driving (Smith System)	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
Special Education Student Handling	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
Wheelchair Securement & ADA Compliance	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
Student Management & De-Escalation	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
Technology Systems (Driver App, GPS, Cameras)	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
Emergency Evacuation Procedures	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
FERPA & Student Privacy	*X hrs*	*X hrs*
Total	***XX hrs***	***XX hrs***

Note that all training hours meet or exceed Rhode Island regulatory requirements, including the 10-hour school bus driver training course (or abbreviated course for CDL holders per the 2025 legislation).

RIDE's Current Training Standards: RIDE currently requires **17 hours of annual training** for all statewide drivers and aides, plus **8 hours of de-escalation training** specifically for drivers and aides assigned to special education buses. Sentry's training management module tracks certification status, schedules refresher courses, and alerts supervisors when drivers approach credential expiration—ensuring 100% compliance with these requirements across all zone operators.

8.3 Item 3: Maintenance Intervals

Describe Sentry's recommended maintenance intervals and how the platform enforces compliance.

Service Type	Interval	Scope
PM-A (Basic)	*Every X miles or X days*	*Oil change, fluid check, belt/hose inspection, tire pressure, lights*
PM-B (Intermediate)	*Every X miles or X days*	*PM-A + brake inspection, suspension, steering, exhaust, battery*
PM-C (Comprehensive)	*Every X miles or X days*	*PM-B + transmission service, coolant flush, full electrical, body integrity*
Annual DOT Inspection	Annual	*Full Federal/State inspection per FMCSA standards*
Pre-Trip Inspection	Daily	*Driver walk-around per FMCSA §396.13, digitally logged via driver app*
Post-Trip Inspection	Daily	*Interior check for students, equipment condition, defect reporting*

Technology-Enforced Compliance

Describe how Sentry's platform automatically flags vehicles approaching PM due dates, prevents dispatch of overdue vehicles, and generates compliance reports for RIDE oversight. This ensures that maintenance is not deferred due to operator scheduling pressure.

9 Timeline

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Timeline (Question 1, parts a–d)

RIDE's Proposed Timeline:
RFP publication: Late spring 2026
Responses due: Summer 2026
Contract award: November 2026
Service start: July 1, 2027 (summer school)

9.1 Question 1(a): Proposed Timeline Modifications

"Is there anything your company or organization would modify within the proposed timeline that would be more conducive to your success?"

Address whether the timeline works for Sentry and what modifications would improve outcomes. Key points:

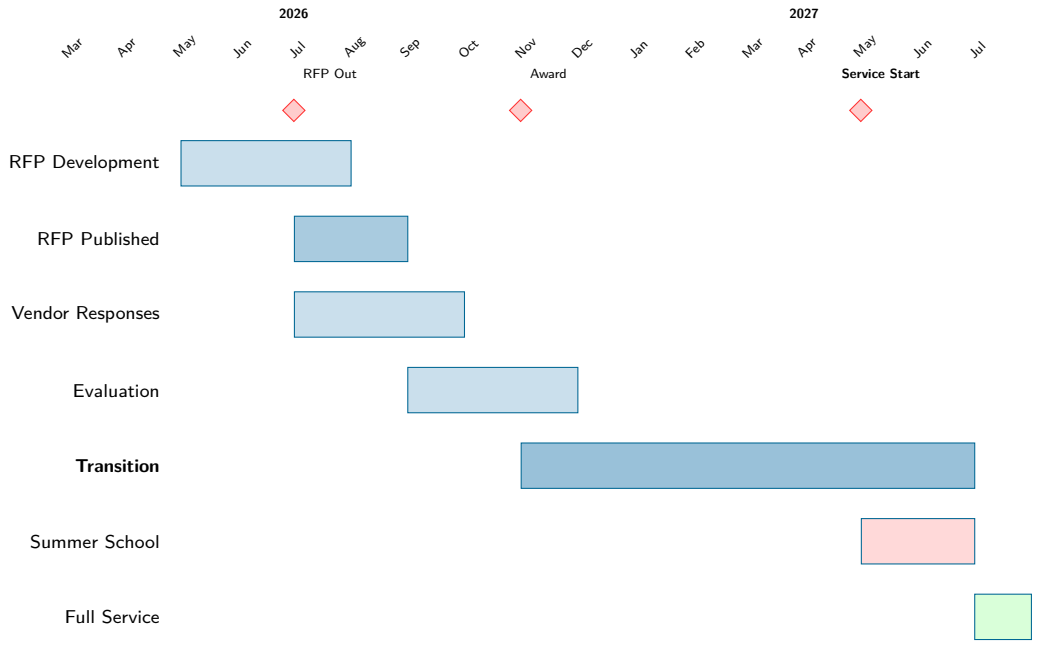
8-Month Transition Is Tight:

The November 2026 award to July 2027 service start provides approximately 8 months for transition. For a technology provider, this is feasible for software deployment, integration, and training. However, for bus operators who must acquire vehicles, hire/train drivers, establish depots, and build routes, 8 months presents significant risk—particularly if a new operator replaces an incumbent. For context, when the General Assembly originally created the Statewide Transportation System in FY 2009, RIDE phased it in over three full years (14 LEAs in 2010, 26 in 2011, all LEAs by 2012). The current timeline asks for a full system transition in eight months.

Recommended Modification:

Sentry recommends RIDE consider one or more of the following:

- *Move RFP publication to early spring 2026 (March/April) to provide more time for responses*
- *Move contract award to September/October 2026 to provide 9–10 months for transition*
- *Award the technology/system management contract separately and earlier (e.g., summer 2026) so the technology platform is operational before operators begin their transition*
- *Allow a phased service start—summer school as a pilot with full-year service beginning September 2027*



9.2 Question 1(b): Driver Recruitment Timeline

"We are aware of the national driver shortage. Does your company or organization feel like the above timeline allows for the necessary time to recruit the number of drivers needed per what is currently outlined in this scope?"

Address whether the timeline allows sufficient time for driver recruitment given the national driver shortage.

Scale of Recruitment Challenge:

RIDE's STS currently requires approximately 334 drivers plus substitutes. If a new operator wins one or more zones, they may need to recruit 50–150+ CDL-endorsed school bus drivers within 6–8 months. In the current labor market, this is extremely challenging.

CDL Training Timeline:

A new school bus driver typically requires 6–10 weeks from initial application to road-ready status (background check, CDL training, school bus endorsement, behind-the-wheel training, route familiarization). This means recruitment must begin no later than March 2027 to have drivers ready by July.

Sentry's Recommendation:

Allow pre-award recruitment activities. Permit short-listed vendors to begin driver recruitment (at their own risk/cost) before final award, so the pipeline is warm when the contract is executed. Sentry's recruitment technology platform can support this parallel process.

9.3 Question 1(c): Number of Routes

"How many routes would you likely bid on in an upcoming RFP?"

Address how many routes Sentry would bid on. Frame this based on Sentry's role:

- **As Technology / System Manager:** *Sentry would bid to provide technology and system management services across ALL 334 routes statewide. Our platform's value increases with scale—serving all zones enables cross-zone optimization that is impossible when each operator uses a separate system.*

- **As Technology Partner to a Bus Operator:** *Sentry could partner with one or more bus operators to provide technology for specific zones. The number of routes would depend on the partner operator's capacity and zone selection.*

9.4 Question 1(d): Fleet Construct Impact

"How does this timeline impact your fleet construct?"

Address how the timeline affects vehicle procurement. Frame from Sentry's technology perspective:

Vehicle Procurement Lead Times:

New school bus delivery currently requires 6–12 months from order. An 8-month transition period may not allow sufficient time for operators to order and receive new vehicles, particularly wheelchair-accessible Type A buses with custom modifications.

Video System Installation:

The July 1, 2027 mandate requires all new buses to have live digital video violation detection systems. Sentry's camera systems can be installed in 1–2 days per vehicle, but installation must be scheduled after vehicle delivery. A compressed timeline increases the risk of buses entering service without cameras installed.

Fleet Transition Strategy:

Sentry recommends RIDE require outgoing operators to make vehicles available for purchase or lease by incoming operators, reducing the need for new vehicle procurement during the transition period.

10 Information Gathering Templates (Optional)

"RIDE is interested in learning more about potential bidders' school bus operations and services offered. Please complete the following using the templates provided."

RFI Reference

Section C: Information Gathering Templates (Optional) — Technological Capabilities

Note: Sentry's response focuses on the Technological Capabilities template, consistent with our positioning as a technology and system management provider. Staffing model and safety/compliance practices are addressed in the Company Practices Disclosure section above.

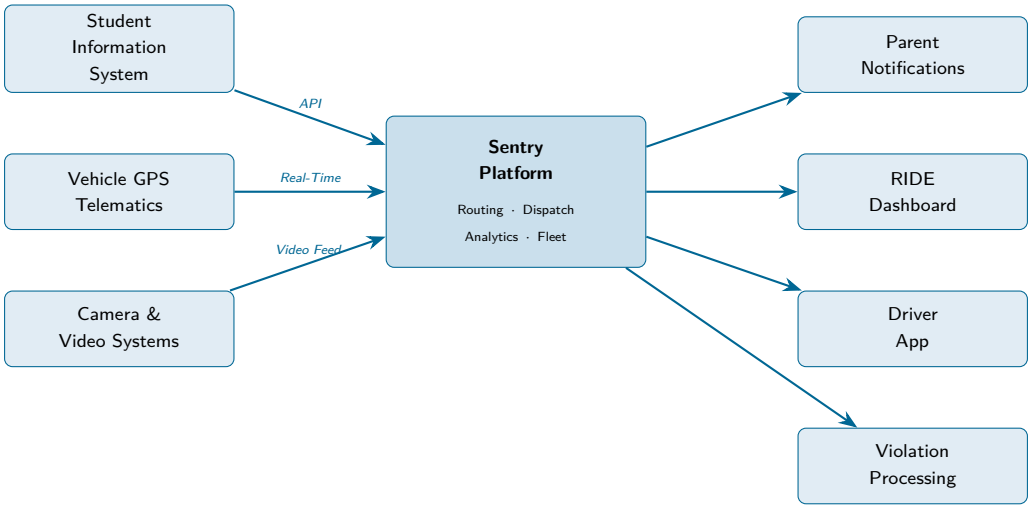
10.1 Technological Capabilities

This section describes Sentry's technology platform and its applicability to RIDE's Statewide Transportation System.

10.1.1 Platform Overview

2–3 paragraphs describing the Sentry technology platform at a high level. Cover the overall architecture (cloud-based, real-time, multi-tenant), the core modules, and the integration philosophy (open APIs, vendor-neutral).

RIDE has already taken steps toward technology modernization—launching a **Parent GPS App** in October 2024 and requiring operators to use digital systems for proactive outreach to LEAs and families for earlier sign-up. Sentry's platform is designed to integrate with and extend these existing investments, providing the unified backend that connects parent-facing tools, operator dispatch systems, RIDE's eRIDE student information portal, and the billing infrastructure that currently processes 700 manual checks per year from districts.



10.1.2 Routing Optimization

Describe the routing engine in detail. Key capabilities:

Multi-Objective Optimization:
Algorithm simultaneously minimizes total route time, deadhead miles, and ride time per student while respecting constraints (vehicle capacity, wheelchair positions, bell times, maximum ride time per IEP).

Geographic Clustering:
Automatic identification of student clusters that can be efficiently served by a single route, accounting for road network topology (not just straight-line distance).

Scenario Modeling:
"What-if" analysis for zone restructuring, van conversion, school consolidation, and bell-time staggering. RIDE can model the impact of policy changes before implementing them.

Continuous Optimization:
Routes are not static. The system re-optimizes as students enroll/withdraw, schools open/close, and traffic patterns change.

10.1.3 Real-Time Dispatch & GPS Tracking

Describe dispatch and tracking capabilities:

Live Vehicle Tracking:
All vehicles tracked in real-time via GPS with X-second update intervals. Dispatchers see all zones on a single map.

Automated Alerts:
System generates alerts for late departures, route deviations, speed violations, unauthorized stops, extended idling, and missed pickups.

Parent Communication:
Parents receive real-time ETA notifications, arrival alerts, and delay notifications via mobile app or SMS.

10.1.4 Live Digital Video Violation Detection

Alignment with 2025 Legislation: Rhode Island's Live Digital Video Violation Detection Systems act requires all new school buses to be equipped with these systems by July 1, 2027, and all buses by July 1, 2032. Sentry's video platform is designed to meet this mandate.

Camera Hardware:
Describe camera systems—exterior stop-arm cameras, multi-angle coverage, resolution, night/weather capability, tamper-proof design.

AI-Powered Detection:
Describe how the system uses computer vision / AI to automatically identify stop-arm violations, capture license plates, and generate evidence packages for prosecution.

Violation Processing Pipeline:
Describe the end-to-end workflow: detection → human review → citation issuance → court/tribunal filing → revenue collection. Reference the revenue distribution model (30% municipality, 30% vendor, 40% state; or 75/12.5/12.5 for Providence/Cumberland).

$ Revenue Potential:
Reference the Providence pilot (October 2024 – June 2025): 7,000+ violations detected, approximately $300K in revenue during FY2025. Describe how scaling this statewide across 334 routes could generate $X in annual revenue while improving student safety.

10.1.5 Analytics & Reporting

RIDE Executive Dashboard:

Describe the state-level dashboard showing KPIs across all zones, operators, and route types in real-time.

Automated Reporting:

Describe scheduled reports—daily service summaries, weekly KPI scorecards, monthly cost analyses, annual performance reviews.

Ad Hoc Analysis:

Describe self-service analytics tools that allow RIDE staff to query data, build custom reports, and export to standard formats.

FERPA Compliance:

Describe data security measures for student information—encryption at rest and in transit, role-based access controls, audit logging, and compliance with FERPA and RI student privacy laws.

10.1.6 Integration Capabilities

System	Integration Method	Data Exchanged
eRIDE (RIDE's Student Portal)	API / Flat File	Enrollment, addresses, IEP transportation plans, school assignments, annual sign-up data
RIDE Parent GPS App	API / GTFS-RT	Real-time vehicle location, ETA, arrival notifications (extending RIDE's existing October 2024 deployment)
GPS / Telematics Providers	API / GTFS-RT	Vehicle location, speed, engine diagnostics
Camera / Video Systems	API / SDK	Video feeds, violation events, evidence packages
LEA Billing / State Aid	API / Export	Automated "expenditure follows the child" cost allocation, replacing 700 annual manual checks with real-time per-student billing
RIDE Reporting Systems	API / Dashboard	KPIs, compliance reports, audit data

11 Summary Narrative

"The response should include a brief narrative with the highlights, key attributes, and distinguishing points of the respondent's proposed approach. The narrative should also explain how the response aligns with the specific goals and objectives stated in the introduction section, with your responses to the questions outlined above, and in the documents linked therein."

11.1 Executive Summary

3–4 paragraphs providing a high-level narrative summary. This should synthesize the entire RFI response into a compelling story. Key themes to weave in:

- *Sentry is a technology and system management partner, not a bus operator—bringing specialized capabilities that complement operators rather than competing with them.*
- *Sentry's platform directly addresses RIDE's stated goals: zone review for bidding, partnership between state and vendors, and efficient deployment of resources.*
- *The 2025 legislative mandates (video violation detection, van expansion, temporary driver licenses) create an immediate need for technology infrastructure that Sentry is positioned to provide.*
- *A separate technology/system management procurement would increase competition, reduce vendor lock-in, and give RIDE independent oversight of operator performance.*

11.2 Alignment with RIDE's Goals

RIDE Goal	Sentry's Alignment
Review zones for bidding purposes	Sentry's routing optimization platform can model alternative zone configurations—whether RIDE maintains the current 7-zone structure, implements the Commission's proposed 9-zone model, or explores other configurations. The platform quantifies the cost and service impact of each scenario, enabling data-driven zone design rather than relying on boundaries drawn from a 1977 vocational school map.
Bid for zones that work best for all	By providing a vendor-neutral technology platform, Sentry enables operators of all sizes to bid competitively. Smaller operators gain access to enterprise-grade routing and dispatch without building their own systems—lowering the barriers to entry that currently limit bidding competition.
Partnership between state and vendors	Transpar's current System Manager role demonstrates that RIDE values the partnership model. Sentry's platform upgrades this partnership with real-time data sharing: RIDE and all zone operators see the same KPIs, costs, and performance metrics simultaneously. The "expenditure follows the child" billing is automated, and the 700-check-per-year manual process is replaced with transparent, GPS-verified cost allocation across all 49 LEAs.

Deploy resources needed for transportation	With ridership up 34% since 2015 and close to 100 more daily bus routes than a decade ago, resource deployment must be driven by data, not historical patterns. Sentry's platform optimizes vehicle, driver, and aide assignments across the system's three distinct populations—PCCT (50.87%), Special Education (24.29%), and Homeless/Foster Care (24.84%)—each with different routing constraints and regulatory requirements.

11.3 Key Differentiators

- **Scale Without Conflict:**
  Sentry manages technology for 10,000+ daily paratransit trips in NYC. We bring that scale to Rhode Island without the conflict of interest that arises when a bus operator controls its own technology—and therefore controls what data RIDE sees.
- **Video Violation Detection Readiness:**
  Sentry is prepared to deploy live digital video violation detection systems statewide, meeting the July 1, 2027 mandate for new buses and generating revenue for municipalities and the state. Our experience with the Providence pilot model provides a proven framework.
- **Vendor-Neutral Architecture:**
  Our platform works across multiple operators and vehicle types. Whether RIDE awards zones to two operators or seven, Sentry provides a single pane of glass for statewide oversight.
- **Data-Driven Cost Reduction:**
  Ghost rider elimination (550 phantom riders identified by the Commission), deadhead reduction (36–51% of route time in Zones C/D), van conversion optimization (147 of 334 vehicles are already vans), and automated billing (replacing 700 annual manual checks)—Sentry's analytics address the specific savings opportunities identified by the 2024 Workgroup and confirmed in RIDE's October 2024 system overview.
- **Building on What Works:**
  RIDE's existing System Manager model (Transpar), Parent GPS App, and proactive outreach programs demonstrate a commitment to centralized management and technology. Sentry is not proposing to start from scratch—we propose to upgrade the technology powering a structure that RIDE has already validated over 15 years. Deploying this upgraded platform in advance of operator transitions ensures that routing, dispatch, and tracking infrastructure is operational before Day One of service—reducing the risk of a repeat of the September 2024 disruption.

Sentry Management Solutions thanks RIDE for the opportunity to contribute to this RFI. We look forward to the forthcoming RFP and to the possibility of partnering with Rhode Island to build a safer, more efficient, and more transparent student transportation system.